

Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee (SOCHUM)

Topic: Combating Human Trafficking in Conflict and Post-Conflict Situations

Chairs:

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Dear Delegates,

We are looking forward to being your chairs at this year's first SESB-MUN conference. This year the Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee (SOCHUM) will be addressing the pressing issue of combating human trafficking in conflict and post-conflict situations.

Human trafficking is a serious human rights violation affecting millions globally, demanding immediate action. SOCHUM offers a key platform to address this issue and find innovative solutions.

As delegates, you are expected to research the topic thoroughly, understand your assigned country's policies and interests, and engage in constructive debate to develop comprehensive and realistic solutions. This topic requires careful consideration of humanitarian concerns, international law, refugee protection, and post-conflict reconstruction efforts.

We are committed to a fair and productive environment and we encourage all delegates to come prepared with a strong understanding of the issue, relevant international frameworks, and innovative policy proposals.

We look forward to an engaging and productive committee session.

Best regards, Maya A.K. & Sophia T.

Introduction

Human trafficking represents a profound and persistent violation of fundamental human rights, a crime that preys on vulnerability and thrives in the complex intersections of global inequality, migration flows, and geopolitical instability. It is not merely a localized issue but a transnational criminal enterprise that generates billions of dollars annually, often at the expense of the most marginalized and defenseless populations. Within the framework of the Social, Humanitarian, and Cultural Committee (SOCHUM), our collective responsibility is to move beyond acknowledging the devastating impact of this crime and to forge concrete, collaborative strategies that dismantle trafficking networks, protect survivors, and ensure accountability. This report aims to provide a comprehensive overview of the challenges and opportunities in combating human trafficking, setting the stage for a productive and impactful debate that can lead to tangible policy recommendations.

Definition of key terms

Human Trafficking

The recruitment, transportation, transfer, harboring, or receipt of persons through force, coercion, fraud, or deception for the purpose of exploitation.

Conflict Situation

A period of armed violence between states, groups, or within a state.

Post-Conflict Situation

The period following armed conflict during which states attempt to rebuild political, economic, and social stability.

Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs)

Individuals forced to flee their homes but who remain within their country's borders.

Forced Labor

Work or service exacted under threat, coercion, or without voluntary consent.

Child Soldiers

Children recruited or used by armed groups for combat, labor, or support roles.

Coercion

Using threats, psychological manipulation, or abuse of the legal process to make a victim believe that failing to perform an act will result in serious harm or legal trouble for themselves or their family.

Exploitation

Included, at a minimum, the exploitation of the prostitution of other forms of sexual exploitation, forced labor or services, slavery, or the removal of organs.

Debt Bondage

A form of modern slavery where a person is forced to work to pay off a manipulated or fraudulent debt that never seems to be cleared

Harbouring

The illegal act of sheltering, hiding, or maintaining a trafficked person

Branding

Tattoos, carvings, or other physical marks forced upon a victim by a trafficker to claim ownership

Background information

Human trafficking, often starkly referred to as "modern-day slavery," is a multifaceted issue deeply embedded in socio-economic disparities and systemic vulnerabilities. It is a crime that adapts and evolves, leveraging global interconnectedness while exploiting its weaknesses. Traffickers employ increasingly sophisticated methods, from exploiting digital platforms for recruitment and coercion to manipulating global supply chains that often obscure the reality of forced labor. Human trafficking thrives in environments where instability weakens institutions and increases vulnerability. Armed conflicts frequently lead to mass displacement, economic collapse, family separation, and the breakdown of legal systems, all of which traffickers exploit.

The roots of human trafficking are diverse and interconnected. Poverty, lack of educational and economic opportunities, gender inequality, and discrimination create environments where individuals are more susceptible to false promises of employment or a better life. Conflict and displacement exacerbate these vulnerabilities, leaving populations displaced and without legal protection, making them prime targets for exploitation. Destination countries, often characterized by high demand for cheap labor in sectors such as agriculture, construction, domestic work, and sex industries, inadvertently fuel the demand side of the trafficking equation.

Women and girls are particularly vulnerable to sexual exploitation and forced marriage, while children may be trafficked into armed groups or forced labor. Refugees and migrants fleeing conflict often rely on unsafe migration routes, exposing them to trafficking networks and smugglers.

The global nature of trafficking means that victims are often moved across borders, making detection and prosecution incredibly challenging. The lines between human trafficking and the smuggling of migrants can be blurred, though they are distinct crimes with different motivations and victim protections. Smuggling involves facilitating illegal entry, often with the consent of the migrant, while trafficking involves coercion or deception for exploitation, regardless of consent.

In post-conflict societies, unemployment, corruption, and inadequate law enforcement may continue to create favorable conditions for trafficking operations. Additionally, survivors of trafficking often face long-term physical and psychological trauma, social stigma, and limited access to justice.

Understanding the historical context is crucial. While the modern fight against human trafficking gained significant momentum with the Palermo Protocol in 2000, the issue of forced labor and exploitation has a long and troubling history. Previous efforts have often focused on law enforcement and border control, which are vital but insufficient. A holistic approach must also address the underlying push and pull factors, invest in victim support services, and promote awareness campaigns to prevent individuals from falling prey to traffickers in the first place. The challenge lies in harmonizing international efforts, ensuring that legal frameworks are robust, and that implementation is effective across diverse national contexts.

Examples of trafficking linked to conflict have been documented in regions including:

- Syria and Iraq
- Libya
- The Democratic Republic of the Congo
- Myanmar
- Sudan and South Sudan
- Ukraine

Major Countries and Organizations

Key Stakeholders:

Source Countries:

Often nations facing political instability or extreme poverty.

Transit Countries:

Nations through which victims are moved, often facing porous border issues.

Destination Countries:

Typically high-income nations with high demand for labor or services.

Organizations:

UNODC: The primary UN body responsible for the fight against human trafficking.

IOM (International Organization for Migration): Focuses on the humanitarian aspects and victim protection.

INTERPOL: Coordinates international law enforcement efforts to dismantle criminal syndicates.

Timeline of Events & Relevant Treaties

1949: Convention for the Suppression of the Traffic in Persons and of the Exploitation of the Prostitution of Others.

2000: The Palermo Protocol: The landmark UN document that formally defined human trafficking and established the "3P" paradigm: Prevention, Protection, and Prosecution.

2010: Adoption of the UN Global Plan of Action to Combat Trafficking in Persons.

2015: Inclusion of specific anti-trafficking targets within the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), specifically Targets 5.2, 8.7, and 16.2.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

International efforts have historically focused on criminal justice and border security. While these have led to increased arrests, they have often failed to address the root causes—poverty, gender inequality, and lack of education. Many past resolutions have been criticized for being "soft law," lacking the binding enforcement mechanisms necessary to hold states accountable for domestic trafficking.

Possible Solutions

1. Technological Cooperation:

Establishing international data-sharing protocols to track traffickers who operate across borders using the dark web.

2. Economic Empowerment:

Creating sustainable reintegration programs for survivors to prevent re-trafficking.

3. Supply Chain Transparency:

Proposing mandatory reporting standards for multinational corporations to ensure their supply chains are free from forced labor.

4. Capacity Building:

Providing technical assistance to developing nations to strengthen their judicial systems and victim-identification training for law enforcement.

Top Sources

1. United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC):

- They are the leading UN entity on human trafficking.
- Look for their "Global Report on Trafficking in Persons." They release these periodically and they are packed with data, analysis, and country-specific information.
- Their website also has policy papers, research briefs, and summaries of UN resolutions.
- Website: www.unodc.org (Navigate to their section on Human Trafficking).

3. UN Human Rights Office (OHCHR):

- The OHCHR provides the human rights perspective. They have reports and statements on how human trafficking violates fundamental rights.

- Website: www.ohchr.org

4. UN Women:

- Since women and girls are disproportionately affected by trafficking, UN Women offers valuable insights into the gender dimensions of the issue and relevant policy recommendations.
- Website: www.unwomen.org

5. Official government reports:

- Many countries have their own government agencies dedicated to combating trafficking.